

Carolina, when she first came to work for us, wore a long red skirt of closely woven wool. As a bride her mother had received the gift of sixty yards of this red cloth from her betrothed, a custom of the Tarascans. With it, by winding it around and around her waist, she made a skirt. At night she used it as a blanket for herself and her husband, and later for their children, against the fierce cold of the mountains. For each girl child she cut lengths of the cloth and this in turn became a skirt. The red skirt, the *falda roja* which Carolina wore, came to her in this fashion. She wore it proudly, as a shield against the world, in the way Karana wore the skirt of cormorant feathers. The two girls are much alike.

Through them I wanted to say to children and to all those who will listen that we have a chance to come into a new relationship to the things around us. Once, in Defoe's day, we were cunning manipulative children, living in a palace of nature. In her brief lifetime, Karana made the change from that world, where everything lived only to be exploited, to a new and more meaningful world. She learned first that we each must be an island secure unto ourselves. Then, that we must "transgress our limits," in reverence for all life.

SCOTT O'DELL

A BIOGRAPHICAL NOTE

By MAUD HART LOVELACE

SCOTT O'DELL's earliest recollections are of a house standing on stilts beside the Pacific Ocean. The tide came up beneath it. This was on what is now Terminal Island, near Los Angeles, where he was born. His father was a railroader, and the family moved frequently, keeping to the same general area. Never during Scott's boyhood was he far from the wash of the sea. This is one of several factors which explain the ring of authority in *Island of the Blue Dolphins*.

From his home in San Pedro, where he lived from ages six to nine, he could almost see San Nicolas, the island on which an Indian girl had once lived alone for eighteen years. San Pedro then was a roaring port, overrun by seamen from tramp steamers and even a few sailing vessels. The school took its temper from

the town, with fights in the school yard every day. Scott's school-mates were the sons of Portuguese and Italian fishermen, and at first did not take kindly to the blue-eyed, Scotch-Irish, too-literate O'Dell. He was the butt of jokes and the target of bullies, and school was a frightening ordeal. Fortunately, he could hold his own in the pigmy battles, and no doubt he already had some of the effortless charm which is so much a part of him now. At last he was allowed to join the crowd on a Saturday expedition to the beach.

Racing to their favorite cove, the boys stripped, climbed a steep bank, and leaped joyfully into the surf. Scott did not mention not knowing how to swim. He would have preferred drowning to confessing such damning ignorance. He leaped, along with the rest, and somehow dogpaddled to shore.

After that, such excursions filled every Saturday . . . in summer, almost every day. The boys swam. They dug cockles and steamed them in a washtub borrowed from an amiable mother. Someone always brought along a long loaf of chewy Italian bread. They gathered abalones and searched submerged rocks for little devilfish and came to know the world of beach and sea.

By the time he entered Long Beach Polytechnic High School, Scott's present easy gregariousness was established. He excelled in water polo and the 440-yard dash. With little effort he achieved fine grades, and in his sophomore year found time to make a collection of synopses of forty plays . . . not for a school project, but for fun.

He started college at California's Occidental when the emphasis was chiefly on military training and getting into World War One. But the war ended, and he had the inspired idea that attending a different college every year would be a fine way to see the world. So he moved on to the University of Wisconsin. He ended there with only a B average.

"I was chagrined. I wanted top grades but wasn't used to working for them."

At Stanford, he revolted against the curriculum, which seemed to reserve the most fascinating subjects for seniors and graduate students. He became a special student, and took twelve hours of philosophy, including the beginning course and the one most advanced, also courses in Shakespeare and Russian Literature. Then, gorged with learning, he went to Hollywood and taught a mail-order course in photoplay writing, producing a textbook on the subject.

This was the glamorous Hollywood of Greta Garbo and Rudolph Valentino, and soon Scott was working in Paramount's technical department, preparing sets. He changed to Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer and was sent to Rome for the filming of *Ben Hur*. In off hours, he studied at the University of Rome, and this ended his unorthodox college career.

When the last wheel in Ben Hur's chariot race had turned, he went to Florence and wrote a novel.

"*Pinfeathers*. It was an appropriate title," he says. For after he returned to New York, an agent advised him to write it off to experience, all 100,000 words of it.

Back in Hollywood, he kept on writing, worked on magazines and newspapers, and ranched with his father, who had bought an orange grove near Claremont. Here Scott discovered the old Spanish families of the Pomona Valley, visiting their ranchos and listening to evocative tales of the past. This led to his fine historical novel, *Hill of the Hawk*. He wrote three novels in all and *Country of the Sun*, an informal history of the nine Southern California counties.

It was in the period of the early novels that he owned Eric von Ebrochtal, the nobly handsome German shepherd, brother of Strongheart, who shared his life for seven years.

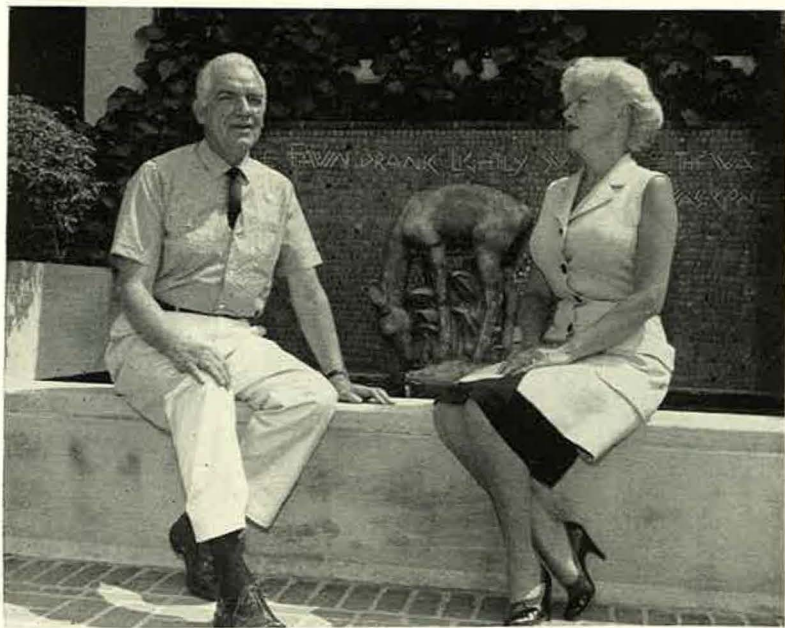
"I took him with me everywhere. I stayed only in hotels that would accept him. He never saw a kennel."

During Eric's final illness, his master nursed him with loving sorrow, played a fan upon him through long hot summer nights. When Scott tells of his death, it sounds like the death of Karana's dog, Rontu.

"Slowly, he walked to where I was standing and fell at my feet. I put my hand on his chest. I could feel his heart beating, very slowly . . . and then no more."

There are French Poodles around Stoneapple Farm in Julian, California, where Scott lives now. He is married to his gay, exciting Dorsa, daughter of Mr. and Mrs. William H. Rattenbury of New Britain, Connecticut, and Claremont. She gives, he says, valuable editorial advice and even types his manuscripts. The poodles romp about the book-lined living room, snooze beside the huge fireplace, sniff appreciatively in the roomy old-fashioned kitchen, and keep quiet in their master's study.

Julian is not far from two Indian reservations, and Scott is knowledgeable about the Cupeños and the Luiseños, but he



Frampton Photo, Claremont

SCOTT AND DORSA O'DELL

in the forecourt of the Scripps Art Gallery, Claremont, California

learned more about the Indian temperament, he says, from the Tarascan Indians whom he and Dorsa came to know during a summer near Lake Pátzcuaro in Mexico.

They lived in the guest cottage on an estate cared for by the Indian father of nine children. Carolina, the sixteen-year-old eldest, was the O'Dells' cook. The others hung around all day and in late afternoon came inside to chatter over chocolate and *buñuelos* with the friendly, relaxed, soft-voiced *señor* and the blonde smiling *señora*. This family sponsored the Americans at secret Tarascan *fiestas*, helped them obtain a native canoe.

"We used to take Carolina to the Friday market," Scott says. "Anything we bought as a gift for her she would take home carefully to share with her brothers and sisters."

It is not hard, when he talks of Carolina, to see Karana caring for her little brother.

Scott O'Dell's life brought him naturally a knowledge of Indians, dogs, and the ocean; and he was born with an inability to keep away from writing. So he gave us the moving legend of Karana.